

Co-Creating Equity Initiatives: Community Accountability and Volunteer Training for Safer Conferences

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Abstract

This SIG will be hosted by the SIGCHI Equity Committee and will aim to co-create an improved Equity Volunteer Training Program, focusing on community accountability and fostering safer conference environments. Building on previous equity initiatives, this session will facilitate opportunities for informal yet structured discussions about the evolving needs of conference equity, especially as it pertains to fostering safer environments for all attendees. We aim to leverage the diverse experiences of attendees to refine the role of Equity Volunteers, inform discussions of common intervention scenarios, and establish practical strategies that promote safety, inclusion, and community accountability at conferences. The outcome will be a strengthened training framework that empowers Equity Volunteers with actionable tools to enhance conference safety and inclusivity. This SIG will foster community building, dialogue, and actionable outcomes to create a shared understanding of equity challenges and possibilities for Equity Volunteers within SIGCHI.

ACM Reference Format:

Olena Pastushenko, Daisy O'Neill, Daniel L Gardner, Ana O Henriques, Victoria Neumann, and Cayley MacArthur. 2025. Co-Creating Equity Initiatives: Community Accountability and Volunteer Training for Safer Conferences. In *Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA '25)*, April 26–May 01, 2025, Yokohama, Japan. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 4 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3706599.3716297>

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CHI EA '25, Yokohama, Japan

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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1395-8/25/04

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3706599.3716297>

1 Background

The ACM SIGCHI Equity Committee (EqC) developed the Equity Volunteer Training Program to address harassment and discrimination through community-based approaches. It was already hosted at various SIGCHI events (e.g., TEI'24¹, AutoUI'24² and CHI PLAY'24³). Currently, the training covers—among other things—identifying discrimination and harassment, bystander intervention, and conference-specific resources. The curriculum engages SIGCHI members with equity topics and methods of community accountability, and supports better understanding of organizational equity resources. Upon completion, Equity Volunteers learn points of contact at conferences and SIGCHI policies on inclusion, harassment and discrimination, and are aware of available reporting pathways. This effort grew out of previous milestones such as the Equity Program at CHI 2019 [10], the Equity Talks series in 2021 [8], the Equity SIG at CHI 2022 [4], the 2024 SIGCHI Futures Summit [9] and other broader initiatives from the SIGCHI Equity Committee, such as the development of safety guidelines and equity-focused recommendations for the conference chairs.

The figure below is the current framework for equity volunteering and the starting point for this SIG.

Our goal for the SIG is to bring together community members across diverse roles to continue addressing gaps in current equity efforts and push beyond traditional methods. The session will be an opportunity for attendees to learn more about current Equity Volunteer Training materials and work with Equity Committee members to develop actionable outcomes not only for CHI, but other academic and professional contexts as well. Attendees will be encouraged to share their own priorities for inclusive, safe, and equitable conferences.

Recent developments in the equity landscape, including growing awareness of systemic biases and the evolving needs, highlighted during recent CHI conferences, make this SIG particularly timely to

¹<https://tei.acm.org/2024/>

²<https://www.auto-ui.org/24/>

³<https://chiplay.acm.org/2024/>

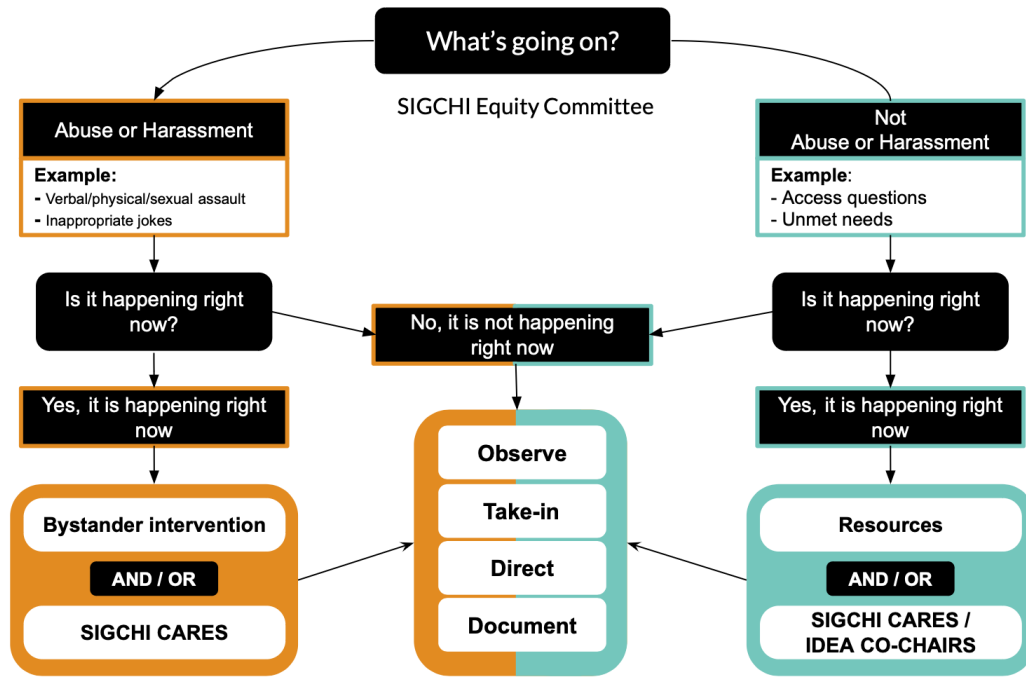


Figure 1: Current Equity Volunteer Training framework

the CHI 2025 theme of “Ikigai”. Indeed, it can be a challenge to find “purpose and balance in one’s life” while our community continues to face systematic inequities, bias, and harassment. These and other factors can prevent many from full participation and finding meaning in their professional contributions. The Equity Volunteer Training is an effort to reduce barriers for participation and create non-individualistic, community-oriented approaches to making academic events safer, more inclusive spaces. This project also aligns with other initiatives led by the broader SIGCHI community, which have touched on topics including equity [6, 13, 14], allyship [5, 15, 16], anti-racism [3], access and disability [7], intersectionality [17], safety [1], social justice [11, 12], and harassment policy [2]. These initiatives emphasize the need for proactive community commitment and advocacy for equity. However, tangible improvements are still required to translate these values into concrete actions at conferences. Equity means not only improving access for those facing challenges, but also fostering an environment that welcomes diverse ideas and perspectives so our field can keep evolving.

2 Community Impact

This SIG is designed to attract a diverse group of participants, each of whom will benefit in specific ways:

- **Researchers** will gain new perspectives on community-driven equity initiatives, as well as practical insights on applying equity frameworks in academic and conference settings. They will also have the opportunity to contribute to and learn from interdisciplinary approaches to addressing systemic inequities in HCI.

- **Conference Organizers** will acquire actionable skills to improve safety and inclusivity at their events. This includes strategies for managing and responding to incidents of bias and harassment, as well as guidelines for fostering community accountability and proactive equity practices within conference environments.
- **Equity Volunteers and Prospective Volunteers** will benefit directly from discussions on refining their roles, responsibilities, and intervention techniques. They will gain an improved understanding of how to effectively handle common intervention scenarios and create safer spaces for all participants.
- **General Attendees** will leave with increased awareness of how they can contribute to creating a supportive environment, even if they are not serving in formal equity roles. They will also learn about the broader equity initiatives in the SIGCHI community and how they can get involved or support these efforts.

3 Topics

Discussions will highlight power dynamics, systemic biases, and accountability, inspiring lively discussion and catalyzing change. By critically assessing community accountability, bystander intervention, and the complexities of Equity Volunteer roles, this SIG aims to bridge previously mentioned gaps. Conferences like CHI are places where individuals come together to share ideas, collaborate, and grow professionally. However, systemic inequities, bias, and harassment can undermine these spaces, preventing full participation for everyone [6]. This SIG seeks to identify gaps and

approaches for change, helping create safer and more inclusive conference spaces. Organizers will present perspectives on community accountability, reflecting on experiences from previously hosted Equity Volunteer Trainings. While feedback has been positive, it highlights the urgent need for these trainings – many attendees had experienced or witnessed experiences of discrimination and harassment at conferences themselves.

The SIG will address several key topics to guide the discussion and ensure productive outcomes:

- (1) **Defining the Equity Volunteer Role:** What should be the goals of an Equity Volunteer, and how can we ensure their role is clear and impactful across different conference contexts?
- (2) **Intervention Scenarios:** Identify and discuss common situations at conferences that may require intervention, including incidents of harassment, bias, and inequitable treatment. How can Equity Volunteers be prepared to respond effectively?
- (3) **Community Accountability:** What practices can be put in place to foster a culture of accountability and support within the conference community? How can the training program support Equity Volunteers in promoting these practices?
- (4) **Training Enhancement:** What feedback has the current Equity Volunteer Training program received? How can it be improved to be more responsive to the needs of attendees and effective in promoting a safe conference environment?

By co-creating the Equity Volunteer Training Program, this SIG aims to develop practical strategies for fostering safer conference experiences. Outcomes will include a refined training program, clear role definitions, and intervention tools, contributing to a more supportive environment.

4 Organization and Presentation Approach

The SIG will be organized to facilitate interactive, participatory discussions that directly align with the main objective: enhancing the Equity Volunteer Training program so that SIGCHI conferences can become safer and more diverse. We will begin with a brief introduction by the organizers outlining the current state of the Equity Volunteer Training program, highlighting both successes and areas for improvement. This introduction will provide context and set the stage for the rest of the session. Following the introduction, attendees will be divided into smaller breakout groups to discuss specific topics, such as community accountability, bystander intervention, and challenges faced by marginalized groups. Breakout groups will be conducted, with facilitators assigned to each group to ensure discussions remain focused, productive, and inclusive.

After the breakout discussions, each group will present their key insights, followed by an open discussion to synthesize the findings and establish actionable strategies for refining the training program. Moderators will ensure that all perspectives are heard and facilitate reflection and questions from the broader audience.

The session will conclude with an interactive brainstorming session, where attendees will collectively contribute to developing a shared toolkit for Equity Volunteers. This toolkit will include guidelines, intervention strategies, and best practices discussed

during the SIG and will be made available to all participants after the session to ensure a lasting impact.

We are committed to making this SIG as impactful and inclusive as possible, while recognizing that SIGs are designed to be in-person only. To enhance access and foster broader engagement, we plan to gather input from the online community prior to and during the conference. This will help shape the discussion by incorporating diverse perspectives and identifying key topics of interest. The outcomes of the SIG will be carefully captured and shared back with the online community after the conference, ensuring that the conversation can continue and evolve beyond the in-person session. This approach aims to bridge the gap between the in-person and online communities, creating opportunities for ongoing dialogue and broader participation, without excluding those who are unable to travel, whether due to personal, professional, or financial constraints. Moreover, this commitment aligns with our sustainability efforts by reducing the need for travel to feel engaged in all of the conference activities and networking and hence minimizing the environmental impact associated with attending conferences. To ensure accessibility for in-person attendees, we will provide live transcription services and offer asynchronous access to SIG materials. In-person wheelchair access will also be provided, as per the CHI 2025 venue requirements. Participants will also be encouraged to share any additional accessibility requirements prior to the event so that the organizing team can accommodate them accordingly.

Emotional safety is a top priority for this SIG, given the sensitive topics of inequity, harassment, and discrimination. Facilitated audience engagement will be carefully moderated, ensuring that participants are encouraged to share but not pressured. Attendees can engage at their comfort level, prioritizing their well-being. We will introduce a code of conduct to establish clear norms for respectful interaction, promoting a balanced environment of open dialogue and safety. Breakout groups will be organized to lower barriers to active participation, and an anonymous Slido will allow participants to share concerns discreetly without the risk of being identified or singled out.

5 Post-conference Plans

The outcomes of this SIG are twofold: organizers will receive valuable feedback to improve the Equity Volunteer Training Program, while attendees will get familiarized with practical tools for fostering equity at future events. Post-conference, we plan to create a public report summarizing discussions and updates to the training framework, and potentially write an *Interactions*⁴ article. As an official committee, we are in a unique position to collaborate directly with conference chairs and SIGCHI Leadership to ensure the outcomes of this session are translated into meaningful actions that extend beyond conference discussions. Our goal is to integrate the refined training strategies into ongoing equity initiatives across SIGCHI events, creating a lasting impact. We will work closely with leadership, ensuring that the insights gained from this SIG lead to concrete improvements that benefit the entire community.

⁴<https://interactions.acm.org>

6 Organizers

- **Olena Pastushenko** (they/them, Brno University of Technology): Finalizing their PhD focused on biases and equity-related issues in gamified education. Olena has extensive experience in DEI initiatives and is committed to amplifying marginalized voices, ensuring the training reflects diverse experiences.
- **Daisy O'Neill** (she/her, Eindhoven University of Technology): A PhD student researching feminist design practices in nutrition care, emphasizing fat liberation. Daisy is also involved in equity efforts to support PhD candidates facing abuses of power and initiatives to promote gender equity in academia.
- **Victoria Neumann** (they/them, Lancaster University): Victoria researches consent across different data sharing settings and works on making academic and community events more inclusive and accessible.
- **Daniel L. Gardner** (he/him, Robert Gordon University): A lecturer and researcher focusing on inequitable interactions with digital media. Daniel employs community-centered participatory design research to collaboratively create more equitable and accessible technologies.
- **Ana O. Henriques** (she/they, Instituto Superior Técnico): A PhD candidate in Digital Media, developing community-led feminist ethical frameworks. Ana's work centers on concepts of equity, justice, and care, applying intersectional approaches to digital media and HCI ethics.
- **Cayley MacArthur** (she/they, University of Waterloo Stratford): Cayley is an assistant professor in interaction design and UX research, specializing in HCI with a focus on inclusive technologies and fostering inclusion within the tech community.

7 Conclusion

This SIG represents an important opportunity to collaboratively address the ongoing equity challenges faced by the SIGCHI community. By creating a space where diverse community members can engage in meaningful discussions, share experiences, and co-create solutions, we aim to refine and expand the Equity Volunteer Training Program in substantial ways. The insights will also contribute to broader equity efforts across SIGCHI conferences. Our approach, focused on leveraging community-driven perspectives and lived experiences, will ensure that the outcomes are both relevant and impactful. By establishing practical tools, clear intervention strategies, and an enhanced training framework, this SIG strives to make SIGCHI conferences safer, more inclusive, and empowering spaces for everyone. We envision this as the start of an ongoing, community-wide movement toward greater accountability, support, and collaboration, ensuring that equity remains at the forefront of the SIGCHI agenda.

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